

Enter the Viet Cong

In December 1960, the National Liberation Front (NLF)—or the National Front for the Liberation of South Vietnam (NFLSV)—was founded at a conference in Tay Ninh province in South Vietnam. The US viewed the NLF as an arm of North Vietnam and called its military wing the Viet Cong—short for Vietnam communists.

By then, insurgents dominated large areas of the Mekong Delta, the Central Highlands, and the coastal plains. Their fighting strength had risen to an estimated 25,000 guerrillas, while the NLF's political wing had as many as 200,000 active sympathizers. Washington responded by sending in more weapons, training, and aid to support Diem.



Transporting the troops

South Vietnamese soldiers wait to be picked up by US helicopters in 1962. While North Vietnam armed and trained the communists, the US plowed resources into supporting the Diem regime and the ARVN.

“It is extremely difficult to **identify an enemy** unless he is **in uniform** or shooting at you.”

KNOW YOUR ENEMY, ISSUED BY THE DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE, 1966